

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Easy-Medium Misuse risk: Low

WHY IT WORKS

People make better decisions when criteria are named before options are evaluated — anchoring on a shared frame prevents the discussion from becoming a preference competition. The frame is the agreement beneath the disagreement.

WHAT IT IS (AND ISN'T)

- Not controlling the outcome — a frame makes the choice visible; it does not make the choice.
- Not process for its own sake — thirty seconds of framing is what makes the next hour count.
- It is naming the decision, the options, the trade-offs, and the owner so the group argues about the choice instead of circling it.

THE PAYOFF

How it lands: Meetings with them in the room end with decisions instead of another meeting.

Principle: Groups do not struggle to decide — they struggle to agree what is being decided; whoever names the frame quietly leads the room.

What you gain

- Shorter meetings that actually land decisions
- Trade-offs chosen consciously instead of discovered later
- Fewer relitigated decisions — a framed choice stays chosen
- Influence without authority — the framer shapes the discussion
- Clear owners, so decisions survive contact with the following week

Why most people fail at it

- They dive into advocacy before anyone agrees what the question is.
- They leave the options implicit, so each person argues against a different imagined choice.
- They dodge the trade-off, so the group picks an option without accepting its cost.
- Nobody names the owner, so the 'decision' evaporates by the next meeting.

CORE FORMULA

Name the decision -> Options on the table -> Stakes and trade-offs -> Who decides

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before any group decision, spend thirty seconds naming: what decision are we making, what are the options, and who makes the final call?

BEST FOR

- Group decisions that stall without a clear frame
- High-stakes decisions where options need to be visible
- Meetings that run long without landing on a decision
- Situations where 'who decides' is ambiguous

METHOD, STEP BY STEP

1. Decision — Name the decision

Say precisely what is being decided — and, as usefully, what is not. A one-sentence decision statement stops three parallel conversations before they start.

Fog: 'So, we should probably talk about the platform situation.'

Named: 'The decision today: do we migrate in Q3 or Q4? Whether we migrate is already settled.'

2. Options — Put the options on the table

List them explicitly, including the unglamorous ones — delay, do nothing, a smaller version. Ask what is missing before anyone advocates.

Implicit: 'Well, everyone knows what the choices are.'

Explicit: 'Three options: build, buy, or wait six months. Have I missed one?'

3. Trade-offs — Name the stakes and trade-offs

For each live option, say what it wins and what it costs. A trade-off left unspoken does not disappear — it just gets discovered after the decision.

Dodged: 'Both options are great, honestly.'

Named: 'Build gives us control but costs two quarters. Buy is live next month but locks us in for three years.'

4. Owner — Name who decides

Before discussion, say who makes the final call and what the group's role is — deciding, advising, or informing. Ambiguity here is why decisions dissolve within a week.

Ambiguous: 'Let us see where the group lands.'

Owned: 'Dana makes this call. We are here to sharpen her options, not to vote.'

FIELD TIP

The frame must arrive before the first opinion does.

Once positions are staked, framing sounds like a tactic to win — everyone hears the frame as a move for your side. Offered before advocacy begins, the same frame is neutral infrastructure that everyone can stand on. Get there first: it takes thirty seconds and it decides how the whole hour goes.

Situation: A meeting about a vendor choice is about to begin.

Don't: 'I think we should go with Vendor A, and here is why...'

Do: 'Before positions: the decision is which vendor, the options are A, B, or delay, and procurement owns the call. Agreed?'

PHRASE BANK

Decision Framing · Setting up the decision clearly

- "The decision we are making is: ..."
- "Let me name what we are actually deciding."
- "The options as I see them are X and Y."
- "The question we need to answer before we leave is: ..."
- "This is a decision about X — not about Y."
- "The decision owner is [Name]. We are here to inform it, not to make it."
- "To be clear on the stakes: if we choose X, we get A but lose B."
- "What is the decision, and who makes it?"

Option Naming · Making options explicit

- "Option one is X. Option two is Y. Are there others I am missing?"
- "I want to name the options explicitly before we discuss them."
- "The options as currently framed are: ..."
- "Is the decision binary — X or Y — or are there more options?"
- "What is the option we are not yet naming?"

Quick Frames · One-line framing moves

- "What are we deciding, exactly?"
- "Whose call is this?"
- "Are we deciding today or just discussing?"
- "What are the options — all of them?"
- "What do we give up if we pick that?"
- "Decision first, details after?"

Naming Trade-offs · Saying the cost out loud

- "Choosing X means losing Y. I want us to say that out loud before we choose."
- "There is no option here without a cost — let us name the cost of each."
- "We are treating this as free. It is not: it costs us the Q3 headroom."
- "The trade-off nobody has named yet: speed now against rework later."
- "If we cannot say what we are giving up, we have not understood the decision."

Framing Under Pressure · When the decision is heated or stuck

- "Before another argument starts — can we agree what question we are answering?"
- "We have been circling for forty minutes because the real decision has not been named. Here it is."
- "This is a one-way door. I want the options and the owner explicit before we walk through it."
- "Feelings are running high, so let us anchor: the decision is X, the options are A and B, and the call sits with one person."
- "We are arguing positions when we have not agreed the criteria. Criteria first."
- "If we leave this room without deciding, that is itself a decision — let us make it consciously or not at all."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Group discusses for an hour with no clear decision framework

Better: Let us agree on what we are deciding.

Best: The decision is X. Options are A and B. Trade-offs are [stated]. [Name] makes the final call.

2. Weak: Naming the decision after the discussion is over

Better: So it sounds like we have decided...

Best: Name the decision before discussion begins.

3. Weak: Implicit options that different people understand differently

Better: I think we are deciding between two approaches.

Best: Explicit options named and agreed before analysis begins.

DECISION TREE

If The group is discussing without clarity on what is being decided

Stop. Name the decision.

"Let me name what I think we are deciding — is that right?"

If Options are implicit but not stated

Make them explicit.

"The options as I see them are X and Y. Are there others?"

If Trade-offs are being avoided

Name them directly.

"If we go with X, we get A but lose B. I want to make sure we are choosing that consciously."

If Who decides is unclear

Name it before the discussion, not after.

"Before we get into this — whose decision is it? I want to make sure we are clear."

SCENARIOS

Team meeting that keeps going in circles

Stop and name what decision you are all trying to make. — "I want to step back — what is the actual decision we are trying to reach?"

High-stakes decision with multiple stakeholders

Name the options and trade-offs before anyone advocates for a position. — "Before anyone argues for a position — let me name what the options are."

Decision where people disagree about who decides

Surface the who-decides question first. — "I want to be clear on who makes this call before we discuss it."

Decision being deferred repeatedly

Name what is causing the deferral — often it is an unnamed trade-off. — "The reason we keep deferring this is we have not named the real trade-off: X vs Y."

WORKED EXAMPLE

Without the technique

You: I think we should go with Vendor A.

Colleague: I prefer Vendor B.

(Debate goes in circles with no resolution)

With the technique

You: Before we pick — can we agree on the two or three criteria that matter most? Then we apply them to both.

Colleague: Sure — speed, cost, and support quality.

You: On that basis, here's how they compare.

COMMON MISTAKES

Advocacy before framing

Sounds like: 'Right, so obviously we should choose A, because...'

Better: 'Before we advocate — can we agree what we are deciding and how we will judge it?'

The invisible option

Sounds like: 'It is A or B.' — while everyone privately considers C

Better: 'The options I see are A and B. What am I missing?'

Cost-free choices

Sounds like: 'This option is basically all upside.'

Better: 'X buys us speed and costs us flexibility. Are we happy paying that?'

The ownerless decision

Sounds like: 'Great discussion — let us keep thinking about it.'

Better: '[Name] owns this call. What do you need from us to make it by Friday?'

Framing to fix the result

Sounds like: 'The only sensible options are my option and a terrible one.'

Better: Offer a frame the other side would also sign — a rigged frame is discovered fast and costs you the room.

READING THE ROOM

Signs it is working

- Meetings end with clearer decisions.
- Group discussion is faster and more productive.
- Trade-offs are made consciously rather than accidentally.
- People leave knowing who owns what and what was decided.

Signs to adjust

- The frame is too rigid and shuts down important tangential information.
- You name the decision without buying in from others — they have a different view of what is being decided.
- Who decides is named but not respected.
- The frame is used to pre-determine the outcome.

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When the decision is urgent and time spent establishing criteria delays it critically.
- When criteria are already agreed and restating them is unnecessary overhead.
- When the decision is a simple preference call with no meaningful trade-offs to evaluate.

RECOVERY LINES

Best line: 'I think we have been arguing different decisions. Can we back up and agree what this one is?'

- "We are forty minutes in and I have lost the question — let me try to restate the decision."
- "I framed that to favour my option, which was not fair. Here is the neutral version."
- "We left yesterday without naming an owner, which is why nothing moved. Naming one now."
- "I think we have been arguing different decisions. Can we back up and agree what this one is?"
- "We chose without naming the cost. Before we go further: are we truly happy to give up X?"
- "I missed an option in my framing — the do-nothing case. Adding it now."

TECHNIQUE CHAINS

Stalled meeting chain

Halt the circling -> restate the decision -> make options explicit -> confirm the owner

Can I pause us for a second?

The decision on the table is whether we ship in June — nothing else.

Options are: ship as planned, slip two weeks, or cut scope and hold the date.

Ravi owns this call — Ravi, what would help you make it now?

High-stakes framing chain

Name the stakes -> lay out the trade-offs -> invite missing options -> decide consciously

This one is hard to reverse, so let us frame it properly.

Option A wins speed and costs quality; option B is the mirror image.

Is there a third option we have not put on the table?

Then we choose A — knowingly, costs included.

RELATED TECHNIQUES

TC009 — Summary Check

Summary Check verifies the room shares your frame before the debate builds on it.

TC015 — Next-Step Close

Next-Step Close is where the frame lands — the decision, its owner, and the first action, stated before the meeting ends.

TC021 — Reframe the Stakes

Reframe the Stakes works on one axis of the frame — sizing the stakes honestly so the decision gets the weight it deserves.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Decision audit

After your next meeting, note: was the decision clearly named? Were the options explicit? Was the owner clear?

Day 2 — Name the decision

In one meeting, name the decision before discussion begins.

Day 3 — Options explicit

Practice naming the options explicitly — not as advocacy but as a shared starting point.

Day 4 — Name the trade-off

In one decision, explicitly name what is being gained and what is being given up.

Day 5 — Name the owner

Before any group decision, name who makes the final call.

Day 6 — Full frame

Use the full frame (decision + options + trade-offs + owner) in one real meeting.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did decisions land more cleanly? Did meetings end with clearer outcomes? Did any framing feel forced?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I name the decision explicitly before the discussion?
- Were the options made explicit and agreed?
- Were the trade-offs named clearly?

- Was the decision owner identified before the discussion?
- Did the group leave with a clear, stated decision?
- Did I avoid using the frame to pre-determine the outcome?
- Was the decision confirmed by the owner at the end?